



Instructor Guide — Lesson 5: Build a Professional Presence Beyond LinkedIn

Metadata

- **Path:** Digital Independence Path → Course 18: Professional Presence & Opportunity Building
- **Lesson:** 5 of course — "Build a Professional Presence Beyond LinkedIn"
- **Age range:** 15–18
- **Format:** Live, instructor-led (video conferencing classroom)
- **Duration:** 60 minutes
- **Tools used:** Canva, Google Docs, a content-planning tool (Notion, Trello, or a simple spreadsheet — instructor's choice), the student's Course 16 portfolio site
- **Prerequisite:** Course 16 (Portfolio Building) completed — every student has a live portfolio site. Lessons 1–4 of Course 18 (resume basics, LinkedIn for eligible students, elevator pitch, networking etiquette).
- **Key constraint this lesson exists to solve:** LinkedIn requires users to be 16+ in most regions, and even eligible students may not have parental sign-off. This lesson gives every student — regardless of LinkedIn access — a complete, credible professional presence built on channels open to all ages.

Lesson Overview

Many students will leave Lesson 4 (LinkedIn) believing that a real professional presence *requires* LinkedIn, and that anything else is a workaround for kids who "aren't old enough yet." This lesson directly corrects that. Students learn that a **portfolio-first presence** — a live site showing real, working projects, reinforced by school showcases, competitions, and community project boards — is not a substitute for LinkedIn. It is a different, equally credible way of being discoverable and trustworthy to the people who matter: teachers, mentors, competition judges, scholarship committees, internship coordinators, and future employers who will Google a name long before they check a professional network.

By the end of this lesson, every student — LinkedIn-eligible or not — will have: 1. A clear map of presence channels beyond LinkedIn and what each one is *for*. 2. A strengthened version of their Course 16 portfolio site, including a simple content/notes section. 3. A concrete plan to add at least one school-sanctioned showcase or community channel to their presence.

Instructor Prep (before class)

- [] Confirm every student's Course 16 portfolio URL is reachable. Spot-check 3–4 in advance; note any broken links or stale content to reference (anonymously) during the demo.
- [] Have the fictional example ("Priya's presence") open in a browser tab, built in Canva/Google Docs beforehand — see Live Demo section below for full content.
- [] Prepare a shared Google Doc or slide with the "Presence Channels Map" (table in Student Lesson) ready to screen-share.
- [] Have a content-planning tool open (Notion/Trello/spreadsheet) to demonstrate planning a content/notes section live.
- [] Look up 2–3 real, age-appropriate examples relevant to your region/school to mention as "other professional communities appropriate for teens": school or district STEM/arts showcases, competitions (science fairs, hackathons for teens, robotics leagues, Congressional App Challenge, Scholastic Art & Writing Awards, local youth entrepreneurship pitch nights), community project boards (GitHub for code projects, Behance for design, a class-wide showcase page), and school-run alumni/referral networks or teacher recommendation systems. Do not require LinkedIn substitutes that also carry age minimums — verify each option's terms before recommending it.
- [] Review each student's roster note (if available) for LinkedIn-eligibility status, so you can privately tailor encouragement without singling anyone out publicly.

Teaching Sequence (60 minutes)

1. Open + Reframe (8 min)

Start with a direct question to the group: "If you Googled your own name right now, what would show up?" Take 2–3 verbal answers. Pivot: "Today isn't about LinkedIn. It's about everything else that makes you discoverable and credible — and the truth is, for most of you, these other channels will matter *more* than LinkedIn does for years." State the lesson's thesis plainly: **a strong portfolio-first presence is not a fallback. It's a legitimate, complete professional presence on its own.**

2. Talking Points: Why Portfolio-First Is Equally Credible (10 min)

Deliver these points, inviting brief reactions after each:

- **A live, working project speaks louder than a network profile.** A LinkedIn headline says "aspiring developer." A portfolio site with a working app, the code behind it, and a short write-up of what was hard and what was learned *proves* it. Anyone reviewing candidates — a judge, a recruiter, an admissions reader — trusts evidence over description.
- **Discoverability doesn't require one specific platform.** What matters is that the work is *findable* and *presentable* — a clean URL that can go on a resume, a QR code on a poster, a link in a competition submission. A portfolio site does this as well as, or better than, a social network profile, because it's fully under the student's own control.
- **Credibility comes from specificity, not size of network.** A student with 12 LinkedIn connections is not more credible than a student with zero LinkedIn connections and three well-documented projects, a competition

placement, and a showcase feature. Adults evaluating teenagers know this — they are not expecting a professional network; they are expecting to see real effort and real thinking.

- **School-sanctioned showcases and competitions carry independent institutional credibility.** A science fair placement, a hackathon finish, or being featured in a school showcase is verifiable and often more impressive to an evaluator than an unverified social profile, precisely because a third party (the school, the competition) vouched for it.
- **This approach also ages well.** The habits built now — documenting projects, writing clearly about your own work, keeping a content/notes section current — are the same habits that make a LinkedIn profile strong later. Nothing here is wasted once a student turns 16 or 18.

3. Live Demo: A Strong Portfolio-First Presence (15 min)

Screen-share the fictional example below. Walk through each section, narrating *why* it works.

Fictional student: Priya Nandakumar, age 15, aspiring game developer

Portfolio site (from Course 16), lumexa-hosted at priyan.lumexa.dev : - **Home page:** One-line bio ("15-year-old game developer building small, weird, playable things"), a photo or avatar, links to her top 3 projects. - **Projects page:** Three projects, each with a 1-paragraph description, the problem it solved, tools used (Unity, C#), a screenshot or short gameplay clip, and a link to the code repository. - **New: Notes/Content section** — a simple running log, updated every 2–3 weeks: short posts like *"Week of Sept 8: Finished the enemy AI for Comet Chase. Here's what I got wrong the first time and how I fixed the pathfinding bug."* This is not a blog in the adult-influencer sense — it's a lightweight, low-pressure devlog that shows growth over time and gives evaluators something fresh to find. - **About/Contact page:** Grade level, school (if the student is comfortable sharing), a school-appropriate contact method (a monitored email, or a contact form), and a note: "I'm looking for summer coding programs and game jam teams."

Beyond the site: - Placed 2nd in her school's regional Congressional App Challenge with Comet Chase — mentioned on the site's home page and projects page, with a link to the challenge's public results page as third-party proof. - Project uploaded to her school's community project board (a shared class showcase site) where teachers and other students can see it. - Entered in her school's spring STEM showcase; the showcase program (a printed/digital event booklet) lists her name and project — she added a photo of the booklet page to her site.

Ask: "What makes this credible, even with zero LinkedIn?" Draw out: verifiable outside recognition (the competition, the showcase), visible growth over time (the notes section), and specific, checkable claims instead of vague ones.

4. Guided Practice: Strengthen Your Own Presence (18 min)

Students open their own Course 16 portfolio sites plus a content-planning tool. 1. **Audit (5 min):** Each student checks their site against a 4-item checklist (displayed on screen): Does it have (a) at least one real project with a description, (b) a way to contact you, (c) any third-party proof of skill (competition, showcase, class recognition), (d) any sign of recent activity? 2. **Add a content/notes section (7 min):** Using Google Docs or directly in their site editor, students draft their first 2 notes/log entries about a project they've already done. Instructor circulates to help

students who freeze on "what counts as worth posting" — anything specific and true counts. 3. **Pick two channels to strengthen (6 min):** Using the Presence Channels Map (from the Student Lesson), each student identifies one primary channel beyond their portfolio (a school showcase, competition, or community board) and one action they'll take this week (e.g., "submit my robotics project to the district showcase by Friday").

5. Discussion Questions (5 min)

Pose 2–3 of these to the full group: - "Which channel on the map feels most realistic for you to use in the next month, and why?" - "If a college admissions reader or an internship coordinator only had your portfolio site to go on — no LinkedIn, no social media — would it tell them who you are? What's missing?" - "Why might a competition placement or school showcase feature actually be *more* convincing to an adult evaluator than a LinkedIn profile with a lot of connections?"

6. Lesson Close (4 min)

Restate the thesis: "You do not need LinkedIn to have a real professional presence. What you need is evidence — real projects, documented growth, and outside recognition — and every one of you can build that starting today." Preview next lesson (typically: pulling all presence channels together into a simple personal "opportunity radar" for ongoing discovery of programs, competitions, and mentors). Assign the take-home activity from the Student Lesson.

Common Misconceptions to Address Directly

- **"Without LinkedIn, I don't have a real presence."** Correct this explicitly and early. A real presence is defined by *evidence of real work being discoverable*, not by which specific platform hosts it. LinkedIn is one tool for this; it is not the definition of it.
- **"Portfolio-first is just for younger students who aren't old enough for LinkedIn yet."** Correct this directly: portfolio-first is not a junior version of a "real" presence — it is the foundation every strong professional presence is built on, LinkedIn or not. Many working professionals with fully active LinkedIn profiles still lead with a portfolio site because it's where the actual proof lives. Point back to the Priya example: nothing about her presence is "less than" — it's simply built on different, equally strong channels.
- **"A school showcase or class project board doesn't count as 'professional.'"** Reframe: professional means credible and discoverable to someone evaluating you, not "adult-only." A juried school showcase or a public competition result is exactly as verifiable as a corporate reference.

Anticipated Student Difficulties & Troubleshooting

Difficulty	What it looks like	Instructor response
"I don't have any competitions or showcases at my school."	Student feels stuck with no institutional channel.	Redirect to community project boards (GitHub, a class Padlet/showcase site, a subject-specific student competition run online, national contests open to individual entry regardless of school). Not every channel requires school sponsorship.

Difficulty	What it looks like	Instructor response
Blank content/notes section — "I don't know what to write."	Freeze on tone or perceived need for polish.	Model that entries can be short, plain, and imperfect — a devlog, not a press release. Give a sentence starter: "This week I worked on . The hardest part was . Next I want to try ____."
Portfolio site is stale or was never finished from Course 16.	Broken links, empty sections, no projects.	Have the student fix the single most visible issue today (home page bio + one real project) rather than trying to perfect the whole site in one session; assign the rest as follow-up.
Overreliance on one strong channel, ignoring others.	Student has a great portfolio but no plan to add a second channel.	Use the guided practice's "pick two channels" step to require diversification — one deep channel plus one broadening channel.
Comparing themselves to peers with LinkedIn access.	Discouragement, "mine feels less official."	Reaffirm the lesson thesis one-on-one; point to the credibility talking points (verifiable evidence > network size).

How to Review Student Work

For each student, check: 1. **Content/notes section exists and has at least 2 entries** that are specific (mention a real project, a real problem, or a real result) — not generic filler like "worked on stuff this week." 2. **At least one channel beyond the portfolio site is identified**, with a concrete, dated next action (not "look into it sometime"). 3. **The student can articulate, in their own words, why their presence is credible** without LinkedIn — listen for mention of evidence, third-party recognition, or documented growth during discussion or in their reflection prompts. 4. Flag (privately, supportively) any student whose portfolio site still has no real project attached — this is the one item to prioritize before the next lesson.

Lesson Close (recap for instructor pacing)

End on the reframed thesis and the concrete next step every student is taking this week. Confirm the worksheet is either completed in class or assigned with a clear due date before Lesson 6.